

Field Report Number Seven

A baker named Ilse opened her shutters an hour before the sun. Children chased paper boats along the gutter after the rain. The old granary was measured at forty paces from end to end. On market days the square smelled of apples, rope and wet wool. An old cartographer kept his maps rolled in a copper tube. He claimed that every road eventually returned to its own beginning.

A cart of turnip sacks blocked the gate for most of the morning. The ferry crossed the lake six times a day, weather permitting. Its captain wore the same grey coat in summer and in snow. Travellers often asked for directions to a bridge that no longer existed. The innkeeper answered patiently and drew them a new route on a napkin.

A small brass band rehearsed in the barn behind the chapel. The librarian stamped each returned book with a satisfied nod. Snow arrived late that year and stayed until the middle of spring. The miller repaired his wheel with timber from a broken oak. Most letters to the town arrived on Tuesdays, carried by a tired mule.

Field Report Number Seven, Part Two

Rainfall in the northern valley exceeded the seasonal average. Every window on the narrow street held a small clay pot of herbs. A baker named Ilse opened her shutters an hour before the sun. Children chased paper boats along the gutter after the rain. The clock above the post office ran four minutes slow all winter.

The schoolteacher wrote the date on the board in careful round letters. Pigeons gathered on the roof of the granary to watch the carts arrive. A violin could be heard most evenings from the house with green doors. The ferry crossed the lake six times a day, weather permitting. Its captain wore the same grey coat in summer and in snow.

The innkeeper answered patiently and drew them a new route on a napkin. In autumn the hills turned the colour of rust and honey. Lanterns were hung along the harbour wall for the evening festival. A small brass band rehearsed in the barn behind the chapel. The librarian stamped each returned book with a satisfied nod.